

"He [Sinner] won the last five matches against me. He had my mobile number, so I had to change my number for tonight. I have tremendous respect for him — incredible player. He pushes you to the very limit, which is what he did tonight to me."

Looking ahead to his final against Alcaraz two days later, the exhausted winner — and third-oldest man to reach a Grand Slam final — said, "I just hope I'll have enough gas to stay with him toe to toe. Then let the Gods determine the winner."

The big questions going into the Alcaraz-Zverev semifinal were clear: Does the German believe in himself enough to win? Or will he succumb to the pressure of chasing his first Grand Slam title after losing his first three attempts?

Their 6-6 head-to-head record and 2-2 mark at the Majors didn't accurately reflect Alcaraz's vast improvement over the past two years. Zverev had defeated Alcaraz 6-1, 6-3, 6-7(2), 6-4 in the 2024 Australian Open quarterfinals, making a phenomenal 88 per cent of his first serves in the last set. Since then, Alcaraz has racked up five Grand Slam titles. Sascha knew he would have to hit groundstrokes more aggressively than ever and not rely solely on aces. As *ESPN* analyst Sam Querrey said, "Zverev has to execute in the big moments."

With Alcaraz leading 6-4, 7-6(5), 4-4 and only two games from the finish line, he tweaked his leg and appeared to be cramping. He told the physio it was a groin strain. Outraged, Zverev protested to Grand Slam supervisor Andreas Egli, "He has cramps. What else should it be? This is absolute b---. That is unbelievable. That cannot be. You cannot be serious."

Zverev lost the protest but ultimately won the set in a 7-3 tie-breaker as Alcaraz, in obvious pain, returned some shots nonchalantly and didn't run for others. The physio rubbed Alcaraz's legs and the debilitated Spaniard drank pickle juice — both actions suggesting the problem was indeed cramps. Alcaraz soldiered on, but Zverev won another tie-breaker, 7-4,

to even the match.

With spectators chanting 'Let's go, Carlos, let's go,' Alcaraz responded with his 14th forehand winner of the deciding set to hold for 6-5. The crowd roared. During the changeover, they sang and clapped in appreciation of his courage and skill, while the smiling Spaniard raised his arm for even more.

With characteristic panache, Alcaraz finished his memorable 6-4, 7-6(5), 6-7(3), 6-7(4), 7-5 conquest with a running passing shot that Zverev netted.

Asked by courtside interviewer Courier how he won, Alcaraz said simply, "Believing — believing all the time. I always say, you have to believe in yourself." Djokovic's improbable but exhilarating quest for a 25th Grand Slam title came to an end when he lost an Australian Open final for the first time — 2-6, 6-2, 6-3, 7-5.

More than a billion watched on TV, and over 15,000 packed Rod Laver Arena, including those who paid scalpers USD5,500 (US) for a ticket.

"It has to be at the top of his achievements if Novak beats both these guys who have won the last eight Majors," said Annacone.

That seemed plausible when Djokovic, playing extraordinary tennis, broke serve for 3-1 and then again for 6-2 in a mere 38 minutes. But the tide quickly turned, and there would be no Houdini escape acts.



Familiar script: Zverev failed to capitalise on Alcaraz's mid-match cramps and eventually went down in five sets. AFP

Alcaraz was too fast, too powerful, too talented and too determined. As John McEnroe said after Alcaraz fashioned a forehand drop-shot winner at 4-3, 15-love in the third set, "He has more options than anyone who has ever played the game. He's 22, but he's a genius out there."

With Djokovic serving at 5-6 in the fourth set, Alcaraz won a mesmerising 24-shot power rally that resembled a pinball machine gone haywire. When a Djokovic forehand landed beyond the baseline on championship point, Alcaraz collapsed on his back and covered his face with his hands.

The smiling, gracious Serb walked across the court to congratulate the champion, affectionately placing his arm on Alcaraz's shoulder and a hand on his head.

When Djokovic began his speech, the fans chanted, "Nole, Nole, Nole." Paying tribute to Alcaraz, he said, "What you've been doing is historic, legendary." Then he joked, "I'm sure we'll be seeing each other many more times in the next ten years."

As Alcaraz left the court, he signed the camera lens: 'JOB FINISHED 4/4 COMPLETE!!'